Unknown to Dalvi and the brigade signals team, both 9 Punjab and 4 Grenadiers were also patched in on the line and heard the conversation between the brigade commander and the GOC. The effect of this conversation on the morale of the two commanding officers and the battalions can best be gauged from how events played out the next morning.

THE ENDLESS NIGHT

The bitter cold had seeped into his bones. His feet had now been numb for days and the pain in his hands was quite unbearable. Subedar Dashrath Singh wrapped his blanket tightly around himself and stared into the darkness. To his left was nothing but dense jungle; the next Indian position at Bridge 4 seemed to be miles away. Behind him was the Tsangdhar slope, which further up was held by 1/9 GR. In the open defences, he could make out the shadow of his platoon, each man, like him, straining to look out into the darkness until his eyes watered from the strain. Dashrath was painfully aware of the huge gaps all around him.

The fires on the opposite slope were bothering the JCO. ‘I now think,’ he later told me, ‘that there was nothing haphazard about those camp fires. I think each one was a beacon of sorts that allowed the infiltrating Chinese behind us to get their bearings in the pitch dark. Even at a distance the flickering flames were hypnotizing. It was hard to take your eyes away from the fires.’ Earlier that evening, as the Rajputs at Temporary Bridge prepared to face yet another freezing night, a herd of approximately seventy yak had burst through the opposite bank of the Nam Ka Chu, splashed through the river and stampeded through the Rajput positions. It was obvious the Chinese were testing the depth and the flow of the water, while also checking if any wires and mines had been laid by the Indians. ‘It could be a deception,’ Dashrath had told Major Sethi and Major Pant shortly after the last animal had weaved its way through the Rajput positions. ‘Their observation posts know we don’t have mines. I also don’t think they’ll play to our strength by attacking frontally across the river tomorrow.’

Major Pant’s presence was reassuring. He was an energetic individual with a forceful way of getting things done. Though he was one of the most educated officers in the unit (having done his masters from Allahabad University) he had not had too many staff appointments. He was, as other officers would say, ‘the hard core of the unit’.